AZAMGARH

Dhruv Singh a.k.a. Kuntu Singh*
75 cases

Akhand Pratap Singh*
38 cases

MAU

Ramesh Singh a.k.a. Kaka*
68 cases

PRAYAGRAJ

Atiq Ahmed* (now deceased)
101 cases

Bachha Pasi*
33 cases

Dilip Mishra*
49 cases

Javed a.k.a. Pappu*
41 cases

Rajesh Yadav*
24 cases

Ganesh Yadav*
10 cases

Kammu a.k.a. Kamrul Hasan* 20 cases

Zabir Hussain*
19 cases

Muzaffar* 27 cases

GHAZIPUR

Mukhtar Ansari*
61 cases

Tribhuvan Singh a.k.a. Pawan Singh*
23 cases

* Habitual Offender
Murder
Robbery
Extortion
Land Mafia
Drug Mafia
Alcohol Mafia
Cattle smuggling

of big investment proposals that Uttar Pradesh got recently. Earlier, the state had an image where the mafia wouldn't allow you to work, carving off a large cut in their profits."

That, however, did not stop a parallel narrative from taking on a life of its own. The Atiq killing was being read (or overread) as part of Yogi's Operation Cleanup, by an enthusiastic public and by his own party colleagues: the felling of a Muslim don sat in perfect coherence with Yogi's old hard Hindutva template. And instant delivery of justice, to the cry of 'Jai Shri Ram!', at the press of a TV remote button, seemed almost scripted for the age. With civic elections just a month away, Yogi may not want to dismount that horse entirely even if the stirrups slipped just for that little bit.

CRIME AND COMMUNITY

At its root, UP's organised crime is party-agnostic and religion-neutral. To a degree not entirely grasped in the public eye, so is Yogi's crackdown on it. Just like other domains where he has been trying to rise beyond the monochrome Hindutva hardliner image to reach for a more universalist governance approach, statistics reveal Yogi's iron fist against crime is more even-handed than is commonly granted: only 31.5 per cent of the 181 encounter victims before Asad and Ghulam were Muslim; and only 13 ganglords from the community figure in the list of 66. The rest are Hindus across caste groups, not excluding Thakurs. "Our actions were religion-neutral, region-neutral and caste-neutral," says Prashant Kumar, ADG, law & order, who became Yogi's most trusted cop after getting local baddies like Sushil Moonch, Sunil Rathi and Haji Yaqoob Qureshi to surrender in court while he was IG Meerut.

WITH A CLEAR MANDATE TO BRING CASES TO A LOGICAL CONCLUSION, SOME 18 MAFIA DONS WERE CONVICTED JUST IN THE PAST YEAR

The next big don in the Yogi administration's cross-hairs: the Mau strongman and former five-time MLA Mukhtar Ansari. Class separates Atiq from Mukhtar—the latter has a strikingly elite pedigree for a don—but everything else matches, right from the resplendent moustache and the feudal sway over turf it signals. Take judges recusing themselves from hearings: Atiq had nine in a row backing off in 2009 on a bail plea, Mukhtar counted one fearful judge on two cases just last year. Or a history-sheet glittering with heinous crimes: Atiq's 2005 Raju Pal murder was matched in scale the same year by the gunning down of MLA Krishnanand Rai in Ghazipur allegedly by Ansari's gang. Or a capacity to run their fiefdoms with impunity from within prison: Atiq had the realtor Mohit Jaiswal allegedly brought to Deoria jail to make him part with a Rs 40 crore property with none-too-subtle methods, Mukhtar is serving a seven-year sentence for threatening to kill a jailor. Or deep embeddedness within the political system: both have been multiple-term legislators. Already in jail for over 15 years, the law is closing in on Ansari with a phalanx of cases. A murder from the 2001 Usri Chatti gangland shootout became a case in January. An ED case on money-laundering is under way and an all-encompassing case under